The Ministry of Listening: Swift to Hear

> ***James 1:19*** *— "Wherefore, my beloved brethren, let every man be swift to hear, slow to speak, slow to wrath."*

There is a ministry that requires no pulpit, no microphone, no title, and no budget. It is available to the youngest believer and the oldest saint. It can be practiced in a hospital room, a kitchen table, a prison cell, or a crowded street. It is the ministry of listening — and it may be the most neglected spiritual discipline in the modern church. James, the brother of our Lord, does not present listening as an optional gift for the especially patient. He commands it: "Let every man be swift to hear." The word "swift" does not mean hasty or superficial. It means eager, ready, positioned to receive. God is telling His people that the default posture of the redeemed soul is open ears, not open mouths.

Solomon, the wisest man who ever lived apart from Christ, warned us plainly: "He that answereth a matter before he heareth it, it is folly and shame unto him" (Proverbs 18:13). How much folly and shame has been unleashed in homes and churches because someone spoke before they listened? How many marriages have been wounded by a husband who answered his wife's heart before he understood it? How many church splits have been fueled by brethren who were "slow to hear" and "swift to speak"? The Preacher of Ecclesiastes goes further: "Keep thy foot when thou goest to the house of God, and be more ready to hear, than to give the sacrifice of fools: for they consider not that they do evil" (Ecclesiastes 5:1). To enter God's presence with a flood of words while the heart remains unhearing is not devotion — it is the sacrifice of fools. Listening is not passive. It is an act of worship.

Consider the home of Martha and Mary in Bethany. "And she had a sister called Mary, which also sat at Jesus' feet, and heard his word. But Martha was cumbered about much serving" (Luke 10:39-40). Martha was doing good things. She was serving the Lord. But she was so consumed with speaking, preparing, and performing that she missed the one thing needful. Mary sat. Mary listened. And Jesus said, "Mary hath chosen that good part, which shall not be taken away from her" (Luke 10:42). The ministry of listening begins at the feet of Jesus. Before we can speak a word for Him, we must hear a word from Him. A church that does not listen to Christ will eventually speak only its own opinions. A believer who does not sit at His feet will eventually serve from emptiness.

In the days when “the word of the Lord was precious” and “there was no open vision” (1 Samuel 3:1), God raised up a boy who did not yet know how to recognize His voice. Three times the Lord called Samuel, and three times Samuel ran to Eli, saying, “Here am I.” It was Eli — flawed, compromised Eli — who finally discerned what was happening and instructed the child: “Go, lie down: and it shall be, if he call thee, that thou shalt say, Speak, Lord; for thy servant heareth” (1 Samuel 3:9). And when the Lord came and stood and called, “Samuel, Samuel,” the boy answered, “Speak; for thy servant heareth” (1 Samuel 3:10). Samuel’s greatness did not begin with preaching. It began with listening. The prophet who would later anoint kings and confront a nation first had to learn to lie still and say, “Speak, Lord.” If God’s people today cannot hear His voice, it is not because He has stopped speaking. It is because we have not learned to be still.

When Job’s three friends heard of his calamity, they came to mourn with him and comfort him. And for seven days, they got it right. “So they sat down with him upon the ground seven days and seven nights, and none spake a word unto him: for they saw that his grief was very great” (Job 2:13). Seven days of holy silence. Seven days of presence without words. Seven days of the ministry of listening. It was only when they opened their mouths that they became miserable comforters. Their theology was not entirely wrong, but their timing was. They spoke before they listened. They explained before they understood. They defended God before they had wept with Job. The church today needs fewer Job’s friends who pontificate and more who sit in the ashes and say nothing. Sometimes the most Christlike thing you can do is close your mouth, open your ears, and stay.

“And Jesus stood still, and commanded him to be called” (Mark 10:49). The Son of God, on His way to Jerusalem to die for the sins of the world, stopped for a blind beggar crying out from the roadside. The crowd told Bartimaeus to be quiet. Jesus told him to come. And then Jesus asked a question that reveals the heart of the ministry of listening: “What wilt thou that I should do unto thee?” (Mark 10:51). Jesus already knew Bartimaeus was blind. He did not need information. He was giving the man dignity. He was listening to the cry of the afflicted. Psalm 10:17 declares, “LORD, thou hast heard the desire of the humble: thou wilt prepare their heart, thou wilt cause thine ear to hear.” The God of the universe bends down to listen. How dare His people stand tall and refuse to hear?

When Paul and Silas preached in Berea, the Scripture records: “These were more noble than those in Thessalonica, in that they received the word with all readiness of mind, and searched the scriptures daily, whether those things were so” (Acts 17:11). The Bereans

were noble not because they had more resources or more influence, but because they listened with eagerness and examined everything by the Word of God. A listening church is a noble church. A listening believer is a discerning believer. The one who is swift to hear will not be easily deceived, because the Word of God is being tested and treasured in the heart. Seven times in Revelation, the risen Christ speaks to the churches, and each time He concludes with the same refrain: “He that hath an ear, let him hear what the Spirit saith unto the churches” (Revelation 2:7). The problem in the churches was never that God had stopped speaking. The problem was that His people had stopped listening.

A wise man will hear and increase learning (Proverbs 1:5). A listening heart is a growing heart. A listening church is a church where the Spirit is free to speak, correct, comfort, and command. Beloved, the ministry of listening is not merely a technique for better relationships. It is a posture of the soul before God and before one another. It is the discipline of the feet of Mary, the stillness of Samuel, the silence of Job’s friends before they ruined it, the compassion of Christ before Bartimaeus, and the nobility of the Bereans. Let us be swift to hear. Let us sit at His feet. Let us stop for the cry of the afflicted. Let us sit in the ashes with the grieving. And let us say with the boy of Shiloh, “Speak, Lord; for thy servant heareth.” Amen.